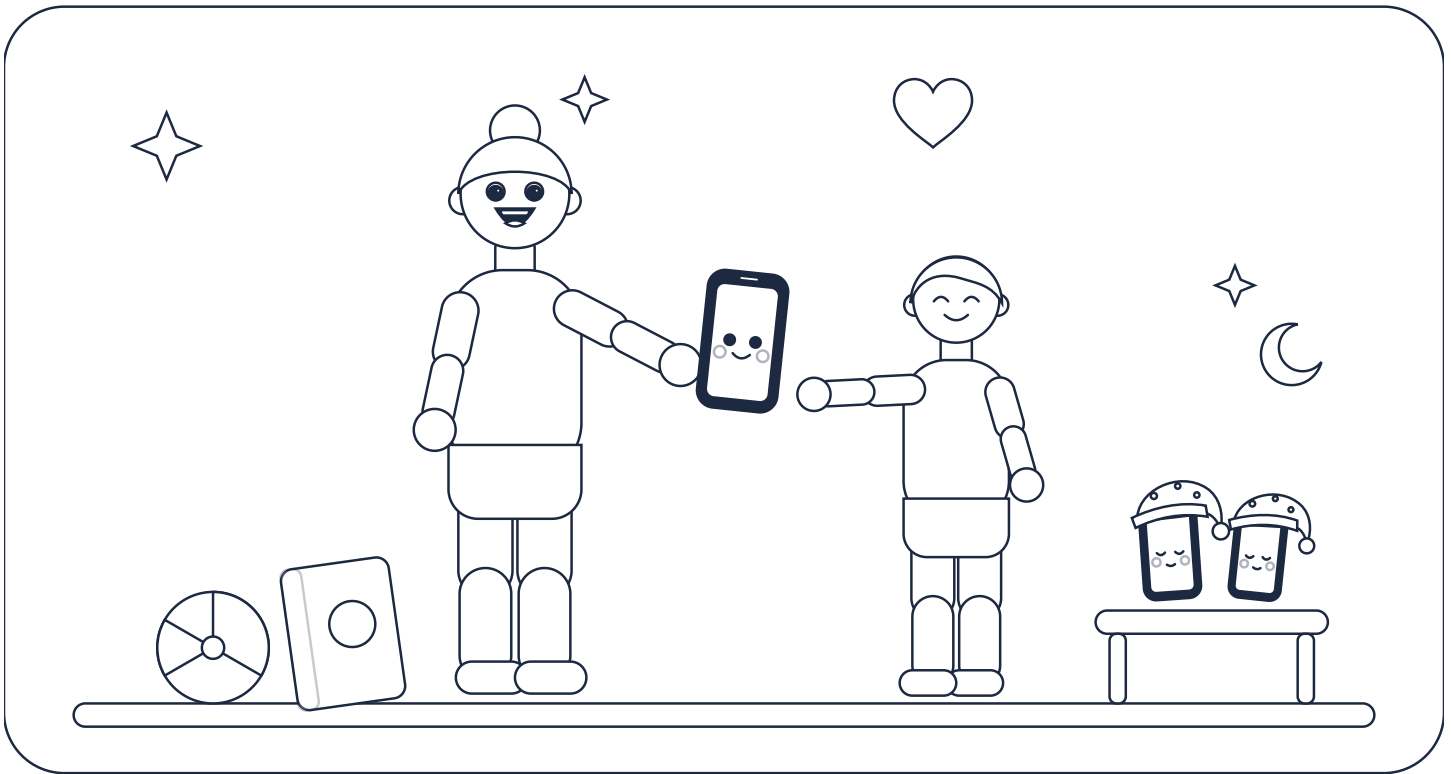




A PRINTABLE KIT FOR FAMILIES OF BIG KIDS · AGES 9-12

First Phone Agreement Kit

A warm, fill-in agreement you write together, plus everything around it: are-we-ready, where phones sleep, and **30 phone-free afternoons** of things to do instead.



16-point readiness checklist



A warm agreement, not a contract



Phone-free zones + 8 signs



Fridge-door tech plan



30 phone-free afternoons

Fillable PDF · pre-filled and blank pages · Low-ink edition · US Letter and A4 · Never names an app, a phone brand or a company

Ten tools, one calm plan

Use what fits your family. Most families use 3 or 4 of these; that's normal. Start with the grown-up guide on the next page.



Are we ready? checklist

16 things to notice, no score · plus a make-it-yours blank
Page 7



10 practice missions

Small steps to try before the first phone
Page 8



Our First Phone Agreement

18 kid promises + 8 grown-up promises to choose from · plus a blank
Page 10



Phone-free zones

7 zones to choose, for grown-ups too
Page 13



Phone-free times

School days and weekends, and the phone's bedtime
Page 14



8 zone signs

Cut apart, post around the house
Page 15



Our Fridge-Door Tech Plan

One page for the whole house · example + fillable
Page 17



30 Phone-Free Afternoons

Challenge rules, tracker, 30 ideas, certificate
Page 19



Monthly check-in

5 questions, 3 months
Page 25



Quick answers

Printing, editing and age questions
Page 6

Fillable pages: every blank line and tick box can be typed into in a free PDF reader that supports forms, on a computer or a phone: names, dates, times, promises, zones, plan answers and the tracker. Printed wording, colors and pictures can't be changed. Every page also prints blank for writing by hand.

Start here, grown-ups

A first phone is a big step toward independence. This kit turns it into small steps you take **together**, with plenty of play along the way.



Set up in 2 minutes

- 1 Pick your starting page.** No phone yet? Start with the readiness checklist. Phone on the way? Start with the agreement.
- 2 Print or open the fillable file.** Type into the blanks, or print and write by hand.
- 3 Sit down together.** Snacks help. Let your child read the promises out loud and tick the ones you choose.
- 4 Post it.** The fridge-door plan and a sign or two go where everyone can see them.

Why this kit, in plain words

Big kids build independence by practicing it: planning an afternoon, keeping a promise, asking for help in person, owning a mistake and fixing it. A phone brings lots of new choices at once. Writing the agreement together, and filling the afternoons with things they enjoy, turns those choices into practice instead of arguments. There is no right age for a first phone; every family decides.

Three talk lines for any page

Ask, then wait.

Ask one question and count to five in your head. Let them finish the thought.

Say what you see.

"You planned that whole afternoon yourself."

Build on their idea.

"What would make that rule work better?" Then add one idea of your own.

Talk in the language you know best. Every language counts. A note on the fridge, a thumbs-up or a quick message counts as talking, too.

How the phone fits in

A few simple ideas hold the whole kit together.



Our big idea

A first phone is a step toward independence. In our home it is a tool for staying in touch and trying new things. It is never a prize, and never a punishment. When something goes wrong, we talk it through and figure it out together.

Four things that keep it calm

- **Never a prize, never a punishment.** Phone time doesn't grow or shrink with chores, grades or behavior. That keeps the phone from becoming the thing everyone argues about.
- **Screens have a spot in the day.** The same time and about the same length each day. You write it on the fridge-door plan.
- **Zones and times are for everyone.** Grown-ups park their phones at the table too. Kids notice.
- **Check in, don't check up.** A 5-minute talk once a month (page 25) keeps the agreement alive.

When something goes wrong

1 Pause.

Park the phone for now. Take a breath. Nobody is in trouble for telling.



2 Talk it through.

What happened? What did you notice? What could we try next time?



3 Re-read and adjust.

Read this agreement together. Change a line if it isn't working.

AGES 9–10

Start with the readiness checklist, the practice missions and the 30 afternoons. Many families wait on the phone itself; the practice still counts.

AGES 11–12

Let them lead: they read the promises, suggest one of their own and help set the zones. Review the agreement on their birthday.

If interest fades

Skip a week. Swap the tracker for a new colorway. Let your child pick the next afternoon. Tired day? Just say “phones at the charging spot, let’s find something to do.” That counts.

Print it, fill it, post it

About 5 minutes to print. Nothing has to be cut unless you want the signs.

Printing

- Print at **100% / Actual size**.
- **US Letter** file for the US and Canada; **A4** for everywhere else.
- Regular paper is fine. Cardstock (65–110 lb / 176–300 gsm) makes the signs sturdier.
- The **low-ink file** has white backgrounds and line art your child can color.

Filling in

- Open the PDF in a free PDF reader that supports forms, on a computer or phone. Tap a line to type.
- On a phone, save the file first, then open it in a PDF reader rather than a quick preview.
- Save, then print. Or print blank and write by hand; it works both ways.

Make it last

- Laminate the tracker and signs, or slide them into clear page protectors.
- A dry-erase marker works on both, month after month.
- Keep the signed agreement in a folder or on the fridge where everyone can find it.

Shopping list (printed once)

- Regular paper: about 10 sheets (the pages you pick)
- Cardstock: 2 sheets for the 8 signs (optional)
- 4 page protectors or laminating pouches (optional)
- 1 dry-erase marker · tape for the signs

Safety notes for the afternoon ideas

- Every afternoon idea follows our published safety rules and carries its own safety line.
- A grown-up always knows where a child is going, with whom, and when they'll be back. Helmets on for bikes and scooters.
- Kitchen knives and the stove only with a grown-up right there; grown-ups handle craft knives and tools. Keep small pieces like cards and puzzle pieces away from children under 3.

Only printing a few pages?

Most families start with these seven: the agreement (pages 10–11), the fridge-door plan (page 18), the tracker (page 20) and the 30 ideas (pages 22–24). Everything else is there when you want it.

Good to know: this kit is parent education and family planning. It isn't medical or professional advice. For questions about your child's health or development, talk with your child's doctor.

Quick answers

The questions families ask most, answered before you have to ask.

What age is this for?

It's written for ages 9–12. There's no right age for a first phone; every family decides. The readiness checklist helps you see what to practice next.

Our child doesn't have a phone yet. Is it still useful?

Yes. Start with the readiness checklist, the 10 practice missions and the 30-day challenge. The agreement will be ready when you are.

Is this a contract with punishments?

No. It's a warm agreement you write together. The phone is never used as a prize or a punishment. When something goes wrong, you pause, talk and adjust.

What can I edit?

Every blank line and tick box is fillable: names, dates, times, promises, zones, plan answers and the tracker. Printed wording, colors and pictures can't be changed.

Does it work with any phone, tablet or console?

Yes. Nothing here depends on a type of device, an app or a company. The zones, times and fridge-door plan work for any screen in the house.

How long does it take?

About 30 minutes to fill in the agreement and plan together, then 5 minutes a month to check in.

What if a promise keeps getting broken?

Talk about what makes it hard, then change the setup, not the child: move the charging spot, try a practice mission, or rewrite the line together. The agreement is meant to change as they grow.

What if my child tells me something worrying?

Thank them for telling and stay calm. Don't reply or delete anything yet; save a copy so you can look at it together, then talk it through. If someone may be at risk right now, call your local emergency number.

Can a second home use it?

Yes. Print a second fridge-door plan for the other home. The license covers your own family's homes.

Is this medical or professional advice?

No. It's parent education and family planning. For questions about your child's health or development, talk with your child's doctor.

Lost a file? Your download link stays in your order email, and answers to download and printing questions are at playbeforepixels.com/help.

Are we ready?

Not a test. There’s no score and no right age. Tick together, then pick two things to practice next.

NAME _____

DATE _____

**Looking after things**

YES, ALREADYPRACTICING

I keep track of my things (bag, keys, water bottle) most days.

☐☐

I put things back where they go, like chargers and school stuff.

☐☐

I tell a grown-up when I lose or break something.

☐☐

I look after things I borrow and give them back.

☐☐

**Time and plans**

YES, ALREADYPRACTICING

I wake up with an alarm clock.

☐☐

I can stop a game when time is up, with one reminder.

☐☐

I finish homework or practice before free time on most days.

☐☐

I can plan an afternoon and stick to it.

☐☐

**People**

YES, ALREADYPRACTICING

I can ask a shop worker or librarian for help, face to face.

☐☐

I can say “no thanks” to a friend and still be friends.

☐☐

I stay kind, even when I’m annoyed.

☐☐

I tell a grown-up when something feels off.

☐☐

**Out and about**

YES, ALREADYPRACTICING

I know my address and two grown-ups’ numbers by heart.

☐☐

I know what to do if I lose my grown-up in a busy place.

☐☐

I can make a plan with a friend and keep it.

☐☐

I know how and when to call the emergency number.

☐☐

Two things I’ll practice next: _____

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10 practice missions

Small, real-world steps that build the same skills a phone needs. Tick each one when it's done.



1. Alarm-clock week

Wake up with an alarm clock for 7 days. No grown-up wake-up calls.

☐ DONE ON _____



2. Numbers by heart

Learn two grown-ups' phone numbers. Say them at dinner, and keep a copy on a card in your bag.

☐ DONE ON _____



3. Paper planner

Keep a paper planner for 2 weeks: homework, practice, plans.

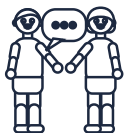
☐ DONE ON _____



4. Lead the way

Walk a route you know with a grown-up. You lead; they follow.

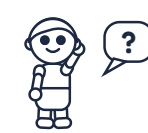
☐ DONE ON _____



5. Make a plan

Plan a meetup with a friend: when, where, and how you get home. A grown-up says OK.

☐ DONE ON _____



6. Ask in person

Order at a counter or ask a librarian a question yourself, with your grown-up close by.

☐ DONE ON _____



7. Snail mail

Write a letter to a relative, address it and mail it.

☐ DONE ON _____



8. Look after it

Borrow something special for a week and give it back in great shape.

☐ DONE ON _____



9. Timer stop

Stop a game when the timer rings, on 5 different days.

☐ DONE ON _____



10. Call and chat

Call a relative on a family phone and chat for a few minutes.

☐ DONE ON _____

Are we ready? Our own list

Write the things that matter in your family, then tick together.

NAME _____

DATE _____



YES, ALREADY

PRACTICING

☐

☐

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YES, ALREADY

PRACTICING

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YES, ALREADY

PRACTICING

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YES, ALREADY

PRACTICING

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Two things I'll practice next: _____

Our First Phone Agreement

BETWEEN _____ AND _____ DATE _____



Our big idea

A first phone is a step toward independence. In our home it is a tool for staying in touch and trying new things. It is never a prize, and never a punishment. When something goes wrong, we talk it through and figure it out together.

MY PROMISES · WE TICK THE ONES WE CHOOSE TOGETHER



Where my phone lives

- ☐ My phone sleeps at its charging spot, outside my bedroom, at night.
- ☐ I park my phone at meals and family time.
- ☐ I keep my phone in its case and look after it.



Kind and honest

- ☐ I only send words I would say to someone's face.
- ☐ I ask before I take or share a photo of someone.
- ☐ If a group chat turns unkind, I don't join in, and I tell a grown-up.



Private stays private

- ☐ My passwords stay between me and my grown-ups.
- ☐ I don't share my address, school or where I am with people I haven't met in person.
- ☐ I only chat with people I know in real life.



Ask first

- ☐ I ask before I download anything new, even free things.
- ☐ I ask before I buy anything.
- ☐ I ask before I join a new group or sign up for anything.



If something feels off

- ☐ If I see something weird, unkind or too grown-up, I tell a grown-up.
- ☐ If anyone asks me to keep a secret from my grown-ups, I tell a grown-up.
- ☐ I can call home any time, from anywhere.



Eyes up, life first

- ☐ I put my phone away when I'm walking, crossing streets or talking with someone.
- ☐ Friends in the room come first.
- ☐ I keep making time for play, outside time and the things I love.

My own promise: _____

Grown-up promises, and how we fix things

What my grown-ups promise

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ If you tell me something went wrong, I'll thank you first. You won't be in trouble for telling. | ☐ I'll answer your questions calmly, even the tricky ones. |
| ☐ I'll follow our phone-free zones and times too. | ☐ I'll ask before I share photos of you. |
| ☐ I'll tell you before I change a rule, and why. | ☐ We'll look at the phone together sometimes, openly. |
| ☐ I'll notice what you do well, and say it out loud. | ☐ I'll keep making time to play and talk with you. |

Our own grown-up promise: _____

When something goes wrong, we

1 Pause.

Park the phone for now. Take a breath. Nobody is in trouble for telling.



2 Talk it through.

What happened? What did you notice? What could we try next time?



3 Re-read and adjust.

Read this agreement together. Change a line if it isn't working.

Our phone basics

My phone is for: _____

Our yes-list: _____

Phone sleeps at: _____

Phone's bedtime: _____

Our screen spot (same every day): _____

Phone-free zones and times: _____

Yes-list: the apps, games and groups you've agreed on. Add to it together at each check-in.

We'll read this again on

AFTER 1 MONTH

AFTER 3 MONTHS

MY NEXT BIRTHDAY

Next steps we'll try together

New independence steps to try as you grow, like walking to a friend's house or planning a Saturday on your own. Steps, not prizes.

Signed with a smile

ME

GROWN-UP

GROWN-UP

Our agreement, in our words

Prefer to write it from scratch? Use your own promises here, or add to the pre-written ones.

BETWEEN _____ AND _____ DATE _____

I promise

☐

☐

☐

☐

☐

☐

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☐

What my grown-ups promise

☐

☐

☐

☐

☐

Our big idea: the phone is never a prize and never a punishment. When something goes wrong, we pause, talk it through, and re-read this page together.

Signed with a smile

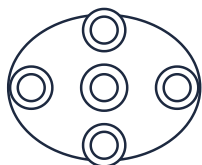
ME

GROWN-UP

GROWN-UP

Our phone-free zones

Places where phones take a break, so people get the attention. Tick the ones you choose. Grown-ups too.



At the table

Meals are for talking.

- ☐ OUR ZONE
- ☐ GROWN-UPS TOO



Bedrooms at night

Phones sleep at the charging spot.

- ☐ OUR ZONE
- ☐ GROWN-UPS TOO



Short car rides

Car time is talk time.

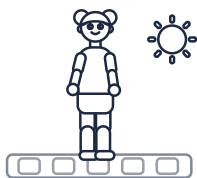
- ☐ OUR ZONE
- ☐ GROWN-UPS TOO



Homework time

One thing at a time.

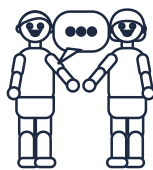
- ☐ OUR ZONE
- ☐ GROWN-UPS TOO



Walking and crossing

Eyes up, phone away.

- ☐ OUR ZONE
- ☐ GROWN-UPS TOO



When friends visit

The people in the room come first.

- ☐ OUR ZONE
- ☐ GROWN-UPS TOO



Family game night

Everyone plays, grown-ups too.

- ☐ OUR ZONE
- ☐ GROWN-UPS TOO

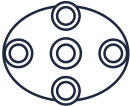


Our own zone

- ☐ OUR ZONE
- ☐ GROWN-UPS TOO

Our phone-free times

A day at a glance. Write in your times for school days and weekends.

	SCHOOL DAYS	WEEKENDS
 Morning Before school _____ phone-free until _____ phone-free until		
 School hours Phone stays in my bag or at home, per school rules _____ No school: use the afternoon row		
 After school Phone-free afternoon (see the 30-day challenge) _____ from ... to ... _____ from ... to ...		
 Dinner Phones park away from the table _____ from ... to ... _____ from ... to ...		
 Phone's bedtime Phone goes to sleep at the charging spot _____ at _____ at		

Our screen spot

The time for games, shows and scrolling. Same time, about the same length, every day. It doesn't grow or shrink with chores or behavior.

From _____ to _____

The charging spot

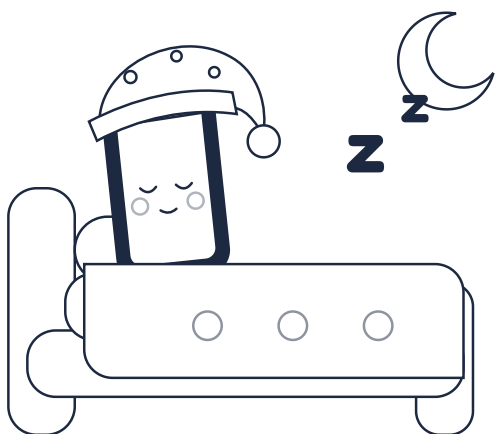
Where every phone in the house sleeps at night, grown-ups' too.

Our phones sleep _____

Zone signs to post

Cut on the dashed lines and tape them up where they're needed.

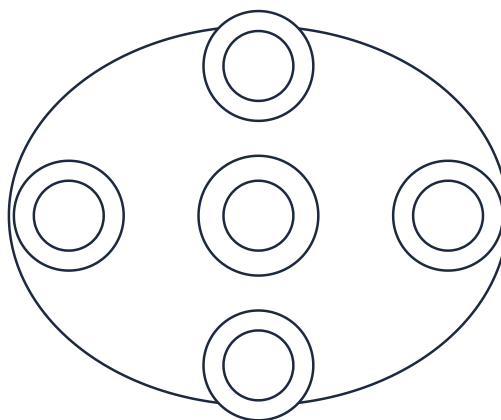
Cut: 4 signs per sheet, straight cuts only. Grown-up keeps the scissors and the pieces away from children under 3. Cardstock and lamination make them last.



Phones sleep here

Good night, phones. See you in the morning.

Play Before Pixels



Phone-free table

Tonight's question is more fun anyway.

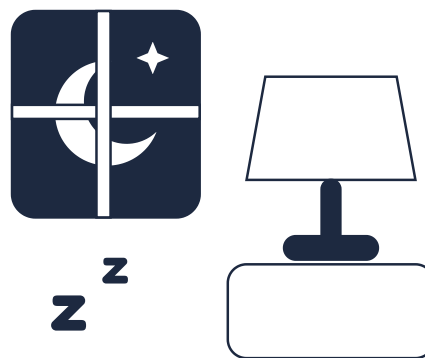
Play Before Pixels



Phone parking

Park it here and come play.

Play Before Pixels



Phone-free bedroom at night

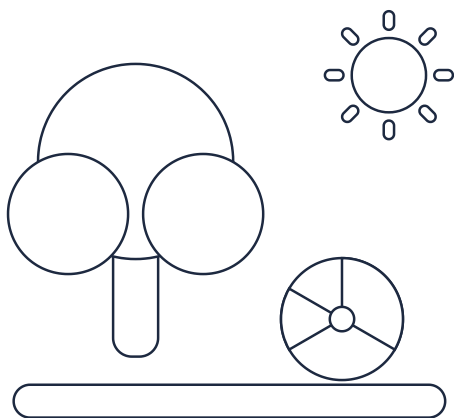
Phones sleep at the charging spot.

Play Before Pixels

Zone signs, part 2

The last one is yours to write or draw.

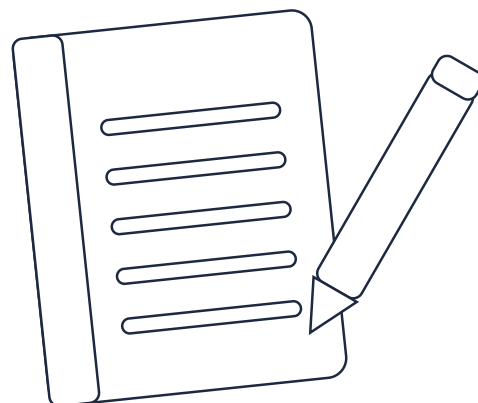
Cut: 4 signs per sheet, straight cuts only. Grown-up keeps the scissors and the pieces away from children under 3. Cardstock and lamination make them last.



Phone-free afternoon in progress

Back at dinner. Ask me what I did!

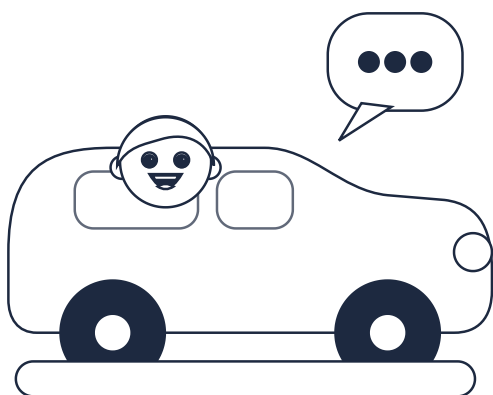
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Homework zone

One thing at a time.

Play Before Pixels



Car talk

Would you rather... ? Your turn!

Play Before Pixels

draw it

Play Before Pixels

Our Fridge-Door Tech Plan

One page for the whole house. Here's how one family filled it in; yours is on the next page.

1 Where phones sleep

Charging spot Kitchen counter basket

Phone bedtime 8:30 pm (grown-ups 10)

Grown-ups' phones Same basket, by 10 pm

2 Our screen spot

From 6:30 pm to 7:15 pm

Screen fun includes Shows, games, videos

Same time every day. Never bigger or smaller because of chores or behavior.

3 Phone-free zones

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☒ At the table | ☒ Bedrooms at night |
| ☒ Short car rides | ☒ Homework time |
| ☒ Walking + crossing | ☐ Friends visiting |
| ☒ Game night | |

Also Library trips

4 Phone-free times

School days Mornings, 3:30–5:30, dinner

Weekends Dinner + Saturday morning

Phone-free days Sunday afternoons

5 We ask first before

- ☒ Downloading anything
- ☒ Buying anything
- ☒ Joining groups or sign-ups
- ☒ Sharing photos of people
- ☒ Meeting anyone new

6 Our go-to phone-free fun

Bike loop to the park

Card games with Grandpa

Cardboard builds

Library + hot cocoa

7 Our check-in

Monthly, on First Sunday, after pancakes Next review March 1

8 Signed by everyone in the house

--	--	--	--

Our Fridge-Door Tech Plan

One page for the whole house. Fill it in together and post it where everyone can see.

1 Where phones sleep

Charging spot _____

Phone bedtime _____

Grown-ups' phones _____

2 Our screen spot

From _____ to _____

Screen fun includes _____

Same time every day. Never bigger or smaller because of chores or behavior.

3 Phone-free zones

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ At the table | ☐ Bedrooms at night |
| ☐ Short car rides | ☐ Homework time |
| ☐ Walking + crossing | ☐ Friends visiting |
| ☐ Game night | |

Also _____

4 Phone-free times

School days _____

Weekends _____

Phone-free days _____

5 We ask first before

- ☐ Downloading anything
- ☐ Buying anything
- ☐ Joining groups or sign-ups
- ☐ Sharing photos of people
- ☐ Meeting anyone new

6 Our go-to phone-free fun

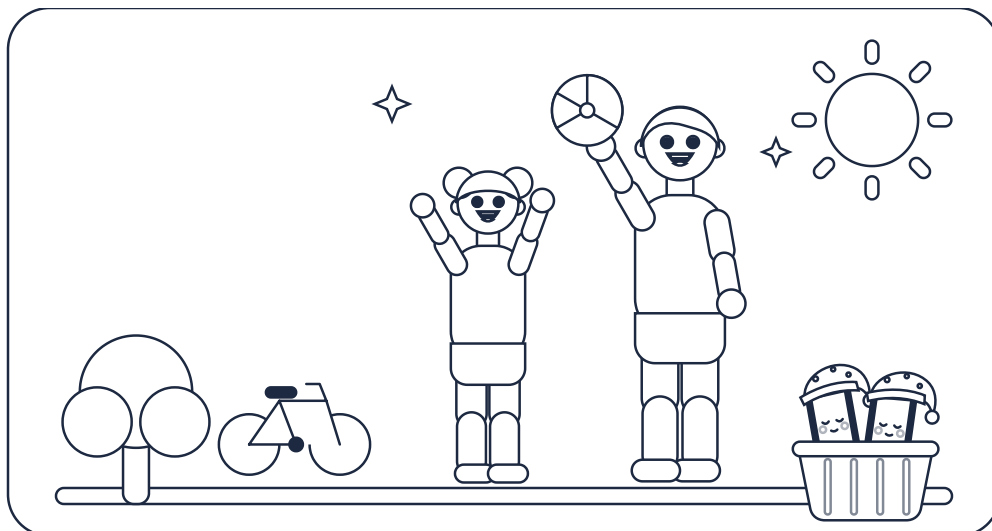
7 Our check-in

Monthly, on _____ Next review _____

8 Signed by everyone in the house

30 Phone-Free Afternoons

A month of afternoons that belong to your big kid: build, ride, cook, invent, explore. No phone yet? Do it anyway; it's great practice for planning your own time.



Pick your hours

Choose a stretch after school, like 3:30 to 5:30. Write it on the tracker.



Phones park

Every phone in the house naps at the charging spot, grown-ups' too if they're home.



Pick an idea

Choose from the 30 ideas, or invent your own. Big kids can plan it themselves.



Color it in

Color the circle on the tracker each day. Missed a day? Just pick up where you left off.



Tired day?

Every idea has a 2-minute version. It still counts.



Tell us at dinner

One question at dinner: "What was the best part of your afternoon?"

10
DAYS

Afternoon Explorer

Day 10: you pick the family game tonight.

20
DAYS

Afternoon Adventurer

Day 20: plan a walk or ride somewhere new.

30
DAYS

Afternoon Champion

Day 30: certificate, plus a together treat you choose.

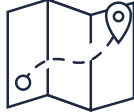
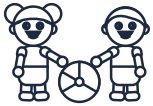
Safe afternoons, every time

- A grown-up is home, or knows the plan: where, with whom, and back by when.
- Helmets on for wheels. Knives and the stove only with a grown-up right there; grown-ups handle craft knives.
- Little brothers and sisters join in? Keep small pieces, marbles and game bits away from under-3s, and skip nuts, popcorn and whole grapes for toddlers.

30 Phone-Free Afternoons

NAME _____ OUR HOURS: FROM _____ TO _____

Color the circle when the afternoon is done. Days 10, 20 and 30 are celebration days.

1  Cardboard build	2  Paper plane contest	3  Neighborhood walk	4  Cook a snack	5  Card magic show
6  Bike or scooter loop	7  Snail mail	8  Invent a board game	9  Nature detective	10  Learn a song
11  Fort afternoon	12  Comic strip	13  Backyard games	14  Library trip	15  Plant something
16  Puzzle race	17  Dance-off	18  Write a story	19  Map your street	20  Picnic
21  Bird count	22  Art studio	23  Teach someone	24  Outdoor helper	25  Sky watch
26  Friend afternoon	27  Interview a grown-up	28  Put on a show	29  Game afternoon	30  Your choice!

My 30 afternoons

NAME _____ OUR HOURS: FROM _____ TO _____

Write or draw your own idea in each box. Color the circle when the afternoon is done. Days 10, 20 and 30 are celebration days.

1 draw it	2 draw it	3 draw it	4 draw it	5 draw it
6 draw it	7 draw it	8 draw it	9 draw it	10 draw it
11 draw it	12 draw it	13 draw it	14 draw it	15 draw it
16 draw it	17 draw it	18 draw it	19 draw it	20 draw it
21 draw it	22 draw it	23 draw it	24 draw it	25 draw it
26 draw it	27 draw it	28 draw it	29 draw it	30 draw it

Afternoon ideas 1–10

26 of 30 need nothing to buy. A grown-up is home or knows the plan for every idea.

#	THE IDEA · MAKE IT HARDER	TIRED DAY + SAFETY
1	 Cardboard build. Turn boxes into a marble run, a robot or a city. Make it harder: Add a moving part: a door, a lever or a ramp. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 2 MIN ☐ MESS: SOME ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Stack 10 things into the tallest tower you can. ☐ Grown-up handles craft knives. Marbles away from under-3s.
2	 Paper plane contest. Fold 3 designs. Which flies farthest? Make it harder: Add a hoop target and score points. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 0 MIN ☐ MESS: LOW ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Fold one plane and throw it once. ☐ Aim away from faces.
3	 Neighborhood walk. Walk a loop you know and spot 10 new things. Make it harder: Draw a map of your loop when you get home. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 0 MIN ☐ MESS: NONE ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Walk to the corner and back. ☐ A grown-up knows your route and return time.
4	 Cook a snack. Make a snack for the family from what's in the kitchen. Make it harder: Follow a written recipe from start to finish. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 2 MIN ☐ MESS: SOME ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Wash fruit and set out a snack plate. ☐ Knives and the stove only with a grown-up right there. Toddlers: no nuts, popcorn or whole grapes.
5	 Card magic show. Learn one card trick and perform it at dinner. Make it harder: Learn a second trick for a two-act show. ☐ NEEDS: A DECK OF CARDS ☐ PREP 0 MIN ☐ MESS: NONE ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Build a card house of 4 cards. ☐ A grown-up is home and nearby.
6	 Bike or scooter loop. Ride a safe loop and time yourself. Make it harder: Plan a longer loop and ride it with a grown-up. ☐ NEEDS: A BIKE OR SCOOTER ☐ PREP 2 MIN ☐ MESS: NONE ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Pump up the tires and check the brakes. ☐ Helmet on. A grown-up says where.
7	 Snail mail. Write a letter or postcard to someone far away. Make it harder: Start a pen-pal swap: one letter a week. ☐ NEEDS: A STAMP ☐ PREP 0 MIN ☐ MESS: NONE ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Write 3 lines on a sticky note for someone at home. ☐ A grown-up checks the address before it's mailed.
8	 Invent a board game. Draw a board, write rules, test it with the family. Make it harder: Add cards, a timer or a secret rule. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 0 MIN ☐ MESS: LOW ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Play one round of a game you already have. ☐ Small game pieces away from under-3s.
9	 Nature detective. Collect 5 leaves or stones and name them. Make it harder: Make a labeled nature poster. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 0 MIN ☐ MESS: LOW ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Look out a window and count birds. ☐ Look, don't taste. No berries or mushrooms.
10	 Learn a song. Practice one new song until you can play or sing it through. Make it harder: Perform it for the family, or write a new verse. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 0 MIN ☐ MESS: NONE ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Hum a song and let someone guess it. ☐ A grown-up is home and nearby.

Afternoon ideas 11–20

Every idea: an easier 2-minute version, a harder one, and a safety line.

#	THE IDEA · MAKE IT HARDER	TIRED DAY + SAFETY
11	 Fort afternoon. Build a blanket fort and read inside it. Make it harder: Add a door flap, a sign and a reading lamp. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 2 MIN ☐ MESS: LOW ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Drape one blanket over two chairs. ☐ Draped, never tied. No cords near necks.
12	 Comic strip. Draw a 6-panel comic about your family. Make it harder: Make a 4-page comic book with a cover. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 0 MIN ☐ MESS: LOW ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Draw one funny face. ☐ A grown-up is home and nearby.
13	 Backyard games. Set up an obstacle course or a target game. Make it harder: Time each run and beat your best. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 2 MIN ☐ MESS: LOW ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Toss a ball 20 times without dropping it. ☐ Clear space; a grown-up nearby.
14	 Library trip. Choose 3 books, one you'd never usually pick. Make it harder: Tell the family the best part at dinner. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 0 MIN ☐ MESS: NONE ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Swap books with someone at home. ☐ Go with a grown-up or as you agreed.
15	 Plant something. Plant seeds or repot a plant. Make it harder: Keep a growth chart for 2 weeks. ☐ NEEDS: SEEDS OR A SMALL PLANT ☐ PREP 2 MIN ☐ MESS: SOME ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Water every plant in the house. ☐ Gloves on; wash hands after.
16	 Puzzle race. Race a grown-up to finish a puzzle. Make it harder: Try a bigger puzzle against a timer. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 0 MIN ☐ MESS: NONE ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Do 20 pieces together. ☐ Keep small pieces away from under-3s.
17	 Dance-off. Make up a routine and teach it to the family. Make it harder: Add a second song and a costume change. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 0 MIN ☐ MESS: NONE ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): One song, everyone dances. ☐ Clear the floor first.
18	 Write a story. Write a story with a twist ending. Make it harder: Illustrate it and read it aloud at dinner. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 0 MIN ☐ MESS: NONE ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Write the first line of a story. ☐ A grown-up is home and nearby.
19	 Map your street. Draw a map of your street or a treasure map. Make it harder: Hide a treasure; let someone follow your map. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 0 MIN ☐ MESS: LOW ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Draw your room from above. ☐ Treasure hunts stay at home or in the yard.
20	 Picnic. Pack a picnic and eat outside or on the floor. Make it harder: Plan the menu, pack it and clean up yourself. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 2 MIN ☐ MESS: SOME ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Eat your snack on a blanket. ☐ Knives only with a grown-up right there. Toddlers: no nuts, popcorn or whole grapes.

Afternoon ideas 21–30

Every idea: an easier 2-minute version, a harder one, and a safety line.

#	THE IDEA · MAKE IT HARDER	TIRED DAY + SAFETY
21	 Bird count. Count birds for 20 minutes. Which kind wins? Make it harder: Make a tally chart and compare two days. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 0 MIN ☐ MESS: NONE ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Count birds for 2 minutes. ☐ A grown-up knows where you are.
22	 Art studio. Paint, collage or sculpt something to give away. Make it harder: Make a set of 3 and hang a family gallery. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 2 MIN ☐ MESS: SOME ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Draw with your other hand. ☐ Beads and small bits away from under-3s.
23	 Teach someone. Teach a sibling, cousin or grown-up something you're good at. Make it harder: Make a 5-step how-to poster. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 0 MIN ☐ MESS: NONE ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Show one quick trick. ☐ A grown-up is home and nearby.
24	 Outdoor helper. Rake, sweep or tidy an outdoor space. Make it harder: Finish a whole job, start to end. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 0 MIN ☐ MESS: SOME ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Pick up 10 things outside. ☐ Gloves on; a grown-up nearby.
25	 Sky watch. Lie outside and find shapes in the clouds. Make it harder: Draw the shapes and name the cloud types. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 0 MIN ☐ MESS: NONE ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Look out a window and name 3 cloud shapes. ☐ Never look at the sun.
26	 Friend afternoon. Invite a friend over for a phone-free play date. Make it harder: Plan the games, the snack and the clean-up. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 2 MIN ☐ MESS: LOW ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Plan the next play date together. ☐ Grown-ups agree on the plan.
27	 Interview a grown-up. Ask a grown-up 10 questions about when they were your age. Make it harder: Turn the answers into a mini family book. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 0 MIN ☐ MESS: NONE ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Ask one question at dinner. ☐ A grown-up is home and nearby.
28	 Put on a show. Write and perform a play, puppet show or talent show. Make it harder: Make tickets and a program. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 2 MIN ☐ MESS: LOW ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Tell a joke to 3 people. ☐ Costumes: no cords or strings around necks.
29	 Game afternoon. Play a board or card game marathon. Make it harder: Run a family tournament with a score sheet. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 0 MIN ☐ MESS: NONE ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): One quick game of cards. ☐ Small game pieces away from under-3s.
30	 Your choice! Plan the whole afternoon yourself. Make it harder: Plan a whole Saturday with a grown-up. ☐ NOTHING TO BUY ☐ PREP 0 MIN ☐ MESS: LOW ☐ PLAY 20+ MIN	Make it easier (2 min): Pick one idea from this list. ☐ A grown-up says OK to the plan first.

Our monthly check-in

Five minutes, once a month. Snacks recommended. Everyone answers, grown-ups too.

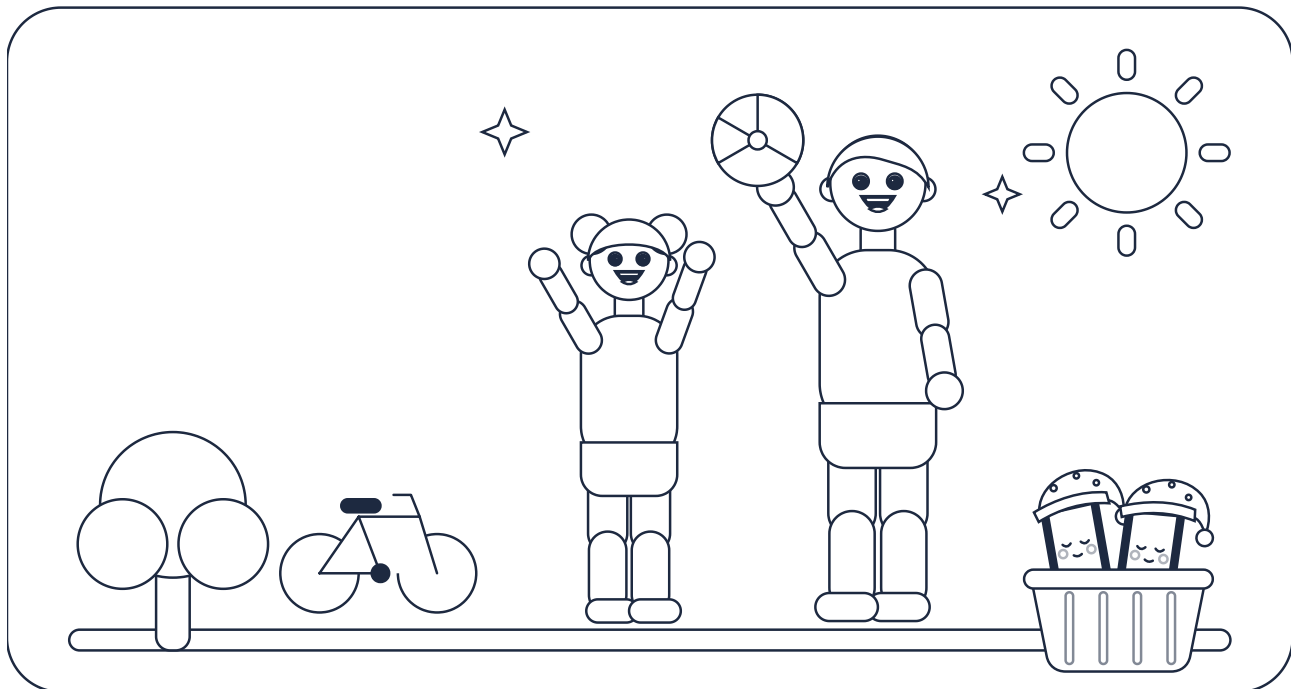
	Month 1 _____	Month 2 _____	Month 3 _____
What's going well?			
What's been tricky?			
Anything you saw or heard that you want to talk about?			
One line to change in our agreement?			
One new step you'd like to try next?			

Something to change? Update the agreement or the fridge-door plan together, and write the new date on both.

CERTIFICATE OF ADVENTURE

30 Phone-Free Afternoons

Afternoon Champion



For 30 afternoons of building, riding, cooking, inventing and exploring, and for planning your own time.

Name

Favorite afternoon: _____ Date: _____

Signed by a proud grown-up: _____



Play Before Pixels

Next for your family

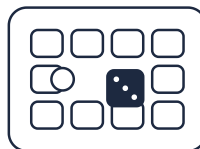
Same calm design, the same “play first” idea. Find them all at playbeforepixels.com.



150 “I’m Bored” Play Cards

AGES 1–12

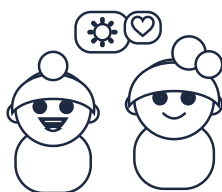
Pick-a-card play ideas sorted by age and energy, each with a talk prompt.



Play-First Family Kit

AGES 2–12

Play First, Then Screens checklists, together tokens and a family plan.



52 Family Talk-Along Cards

AGES 5–12

Dinner, car and bedtime questions that get big kids talking.



230 Visual Routine Cards

AGES 0–12

Morning and bedtime routines, including a 5–12 set.



YOUR FREE BONUS

Scan for a free summer and holiday edition

- 30 more phone-free afternoon ideas for school breaks
- A printable “phones sleep here” charging-spot sign in 3 colors
- One short play idea a month, matched to your child’s age

playbeforepixels.com/bonus/first-phone-plan

We ask for an email and, if you like, your child’s birth month and year so ideas fit their age. Never names. Unsubscribe anytime.